

Xueqi Cheng

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BIOGRAPHY

Xueqi Cheng is a Ph.D. student in Computer Science at Florida State University, advised by Dr. Yushun Dong, and a member of the Responsible AI (RAI) Lab. His research focuses on improving the utility, security, and efficiency of Machine-Learning-as-a-Service (MLaaS), with an emphasis on large language models (LLMs) and graph neural networks (GNNs). He is also interested in social network analysis and AI for social good, investigating how AI can help address societally important challenges.

EDUCATION

Florida State University

Doctor of Philosophy (**Ph.D.**) in Computer Science

2025 – present

- Advisor: Dr. Yushun Dong

Vanderbilt University

Doctor of Philosophy (**Ph.D.**) in Computer Science (transferred out)

2023 – 2025

Master of Science (**M.S.**) in Systems Engineering

2021 – 2023

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Applied Research, Nokia of America Corporation

Research Intern

May 2026 – present

- Research topic: Agent distillation
- Manager: Kelly Wan; Mentor: Dr. Liang Wu

Responsible AI Lab, Florida State University

Ph.D. Student

Aug 2025 – present

- Research areas: Trustworthy AI, LLMs, geometric deep learning
- Advisor: Dr. Yushun Dong

Chief Data Office, AT&T Labs

Research Intern

Jun 2025 – Aug 2025

- Research topic: Efficient LLM serving for multi-turn dialogues
- Manager: Dr. Divesh Srivastava; Mentors: Dr. Qiong Wu, Dr. Zhengyi Zhou

Network and Data Science Lab, Vanderbilt University

Ph.D. Student

Aug 2023 – May 2025

- Research areas: Geometric deep learning, social network analysis, AI for social good
- Advisor: Dr. Tyler Derr

SCHOLARSHIPS & AWARDS

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| • Osher Lifelong Learning Institute Scholarship, Florida State University | Apr 2026 |
| • WSDM NSF Travel Award | Feb 2026 |
| • CS Student Seminar Best Presentation Runner-Up, Florida State University | Nov 2025 |
| • Naaman Franklin Faile Jr. Graduate Fellowship, Florida State University | Sep 2025 |
| • Engineering Graduate Fellowship, Vanderbilt University | Aug 2023 |
| • IBM PhD Fellowship, Vanderbilt University | Aug 2021 |

PUBLICATIONS

Conference Papers

- [C04] **Xueqi Cheng**, Yushun Dong. LatentRouter: Can We Choose the Right Multimodal Model Before Seeing Its Answer? In Proceedings of the 40th Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS), 2026. (acceptance rate 25.7%)
- [C03] **Xueqi Cheng**, Catherine Yang, Yuying Zhao, Yu Wang, Hamid Karimi, Tyler Derr. BTS: A Comprehensive Benchmark for Tie Strength Prediction. In Proceedings of the 31st ACM SIGKDD Conference on Knowledge Discovery and Data Mining (KDD), 2025. (**Oral**; acceptance rate 22%)

- [C02] **Xueqi Cheng**, Yu Wang, Yunchao (Lance) Liu, Yuying Zhao, Charu C. Aggarwal, Tyler Derr. Edge Classification on Graphs: New Directions in Topological Imbalance. In Proceedings of the 18th ACM International Conference on Web Search and Data Mining (WSDM), 2025. (acceptance rate 17.3%)
- [C01] Yu Wang, Tong Zhao, Yuying Zhao, Yunchao Liu, **Xueqi Cheng**, Neil Shah, Tyler Derr. A Topological Perspective on Demystifying GNN-based Link Prediction Performance. In Proceedings of the 12th International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR), 2024. (acceptance rate 31%)

Journal Papers

- [J03] Bo Ni, Zheyuan Liu, Leyao Wang, Yongjia Lei, Yuying Zhao, **Xueqi Cheng**, Qingkai Zeng, Luna Dong, Yinglong Xia, Krishnaram Kenthapadi, Ryan Rossi, Franck Dernoncourt, Md Mehrab Tanjim, Nesreen Ahmed, Xiaorui Liu, Wenqi Fan, Erik Blasch, Yu Wang, Meng Jiang, Tyler Derr. Towards Trustworthy Retrieval Augmented Generation for Large Language Models: A Survey. ACM Computing Surveys (CSUR), 58(15), 2026.
- [J02] Yi Zhang, Yuying Zhao, Zhaoqing Li, **Xueqi Cheng**, Yu Wang, Olivera Kotevska, Philip S. Yu, Tyler Derr. A Survey on Privacy in Graph Neural Networks: Attacks, Preservation, and Applications. IEEE Transactions on Knowledge and Data Engineering (TKDE), 36(12), 2024. (impact factor 8.9)
- [J01] Yuying Zhao, Yu Wang, Yunchao Liu, **Xueqi Cheng**, Charu Aggarwal, Tyler Derr. Fairness and Diversity in Recommender Systems: A Survey. ACM Transactions on Intelligent Systems and Technology (TIST), 16(1), 2025. (impact factor 7.2)

Workshop and Symposium Papers

- [W02] **Xueqi Cheng**. Edge-centric Network Analytics. In Proceedings of the 18th ACM International Conference on Web Search and Data Mining (WSDM) Doctoral Consortium, 2025.
- [W01] **Xueqi Cheng**, Yan Zhang, Sining Lu, Yinqiao Zhu, Wei He. Urban Bridge Conceptual Design Based on Virtual Reality Graphic Engine. In IABSE Symposium Report, International Association for Bridge and Structural Engineering (IABSE), 2017.

Preprints

- [P06] **Xueqi Cheng**, Qinwen Ge, Hamid Karimi, Yushun Dong, Tyler Derr. Adverse Online Social Interactions: A Multi-Level Evolutionary Analysis of Local Patterns, Diffusion, and Community Disruption. arXiv preprint arXiv:2606.20846, 2026.
- [P05] Runyang Xu, **Xueqi Cheng**, Yushun Dong. A Nationwide Benchmark for Wildfire Initial Attack Failure Prediction with Public Environmental Data. arXiv preprint arXiv:2606.15529, 2026.
- [P04] **Xueqi Cheng**, Qiong Wu, Zhengyi Zhou, Xugui Zhou, Tyler Derr, Yushun Dong. SOMA: Efficient Multi-turn LLM Serving via Small Language Model. arXiv preprint arXiv:2605.11317, 2026.
- [P03] **Xueqi Cheng**, Xugui Zhou, Tyler Derr, Yushun Dong. ReAD: Reinforcement-Guided Capability Distillation for Large Language Models. arXiv preprint arXiv:2605.11290, 2026.
- [P02] **Xueqi Cheng**, Minxing Zheng, Shixiang Zhu, Yushun Dong. MISLEADER: Defending against Model Extraction with Ensembles of Distilled Models. arXiv preprint arXiv:2506.02362, 2025.
- [P01] Yuying Zhao, Yu Wang, **Xueqi Cheng**, Anne Marie Tumlin, Yunchao Liu, Damin Xia, Meng Jiang, Tyler Derr. Amplifying Your Social Media Presence: Personalized Influential Content Generation with LLMs. arXiv preprint arXiv:2505.01698, 2025.

OPEN-SOURCE PROJECTS

PyHazards

A Python framework for AI-powered hazard prediction and risk assessment. It provides a hazard-first API for loading data, building models, running end-to-end experiments, and extending with your own modules.

Jan 2026

TALKS**Industry Presentations**

[I02] Efficient Context-dependent Multi-turn LLM Serving Aug 2025
AT&T Labs

[I01] Predicting and Interpreting Churn Risks for Broadband Customers Jul 2025
AT&T Labs

Guest Lectures

[L01] Introduction to Python/PyG Oct 2023
CS 4352/5352: Social Network Analysis, Department of Computer Science, Vanderbilt University

**TEACHING
EXPERIENCE****Vanderbilt University**, Department of Computer Science

Teaching Assistant Aug 2023 – May 2025

- CS 4352/5352: Social Network Analysis
- CS 4260: Introduction to Artificial Intelligence
- CS 5892: Project in Data-Centric AI

Vanderbilt University, Department of Civil and Environmental Engineering

Teaching Assistant Aug 2021 – May 2023

- CE 2200: Statics
- CE 3205: Structural Design
- CE 3200: Structural Analysis

MENTORING**Responsible AI Lab**, Florida State University

• Hugh Long, M.S. Computer Science Fall 2025 – present
Research topic: Wildfire prediction visualization

• Runyang Xu, B.S. Statistics Fall 2025 – present
Research topic: Wildfire prediction foundation models; next position: M.S. Statistics, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor

Network and Data Science Lab, Vanderbilt University

• Qinwen Ge, Ph.D. Computer Science Spring 2025 – Spring 2026
Research topic: Social network analysis

• Bo Ni, Ph.D. Computer Science Spring 2024 – Spring 2025
Research topic: Trustworthy retrieval-augmented generation

• Catherine Yang, M.S. Computer Science Fall 2024 – Spring 2025
Research topic: Social network analysis; next position: Software Engineer, Microsoft

SERVICES**Organizing**

- Publicity Chair, the 5th International Workshop on Machine Learning on Graphs (MLoG) at WSDM'24

Conference Reviewer / PC Member

- NeurIPS, ICML, KDD, ICWSM, WSDM, AAAI, WWW, SDM, IEEE Big Data, CIKM

Journal Reviewer

- Pattern Recognition, ACM Transactions on Knowledge Discovery from Data (TKDD)